I CALL UPON: both the iliad and odyssey begin with an appeal to the muse for inspiration. hesiod addresses the muses in the first line of the w&d, and in the theogony goes so far as to describe how they met him face to face and conferred the gift of poetry upon him. ten of the homeric hymns begin by invoking the muse or muses :-

+ THE BATRACHOMYOMACHIA OF HOMER +

Beginning on my first page, i call upon the chorus
from helicon to come down into my heart, for the songs sake
which just now i have set down in tablets upon my knees,
the illimitable strife, the war-goading work of ares,
beseeching them to bring to the ears of all mankind
how the mice went among the frogs, proudly in their war-strength,
challenging the race of those earth-born men, the giants,
as the story among mortals once had it; and in this way it began.
once a mouse, thirsty from escaping the close danger
of a weasel, plunged his greedy muzzle in a mill-pond,
delighting in the honey-sweet water; but a much-renowned
pond-lover saw him, and spoke to him as follows:
stranger, who are you? whence come you to this shore? who begat you?
tell me the whole truth, nor let me catch you in falsehood.
for if i find you a worthy friend, i shall take you to my palace;
i will give you gifts of guest-friendship, goodly and numerous.
i myself am king physignathus, who across the mill-pond
am honoured for all my days as the ruler of the frogs;
and my father peleus raised me, having [illegible] with
with hydromedusa by the banks of the [illegible]
and i see that you too are fine and valiant beyond others.
then in turn psicharpax spoke to him and made answer:
why do you ask of my birthright? it is well-known among all
mortal men, and gods, and the winged things in the heavens.
by name i am called psicharpax; and i am the son
of troxartes, a great-hearted father; and my mother
is leichomyle, the daughter of king pternotroctes.
she bore me in calybe, and sent me out to pasture
on figs, and walnuts, and all sorts of delicious foodstuffs.
but how can you befriend me,
no, your life is all in the water; while for me, it is my habit
to gnaw on whatever is found in mens houses. i never neglect a
loaf of thrice-milled bread from the beautiful circular basket,

CHORUS FROM HELICON: consciously anti-homeric—the muses in homer live on olympus (11.491, xi.218, etc.), and only appear on helicon from hes. theog. 2 onwards:+ WAR-GOADING WORK OF ARES: the expression is not altogether natural: the work of ares should be war, but this yields the sense war-rousing war :-

GIANTS: presumably a reference to the gigantomachy, the only mythological conflict in which the giants were involved, which was a popular theme in both literature and art. on a literary level, there is obvious point in the proem of a short comic work likening its protagonists to great and terrible monsters. by comparing his mice to giants, the poet effectively elevates his own creation to stand shoulder-to-shoulder with the monumental iliad and odyssey: if tiny creatures can do great deeds, why should a tiny poem not win great renown? :-

WEASEL: a weasel, rather than a cat; the word only takes on the meaning cat some time in the fourth century ad (hehn 1911). wölke (101-2) has a brief discussion of the issue, with some other useful bibliography. on the more general problem of the domestic cat in ancient greece, see hopkinson (1984,167) with bibliography. the reference is probably an allusion to the traditional story of the conflict between the mice and the weasel(s), if not to the galeomyomachia itself: see section 4.iv. the poet plays on his audience's familiarity with the more usual version of the 'mouse-war' topos to conjure up a sort of epic continuity, in which his mice have fought previous battles against the weasel menace :-

HONEY-SWEET WATER: as glei points out (117), although many things in homer can be 'honey-sweet', water is not one of them. the elevation of the mouses standard drink via an epithet normally used of wine continues the comic strategy begun in the proem :+ PHYSIGNATHUS: puff-cheek :-

PSICHARPAX: crumb-snatcher :-

TROXARTES: gnaw-bread. psicharpax's father may be the current ruler of the mice, although he is never explicitly acknowledged as such: he is married to the daughter of king pternotroctes:- LEICHOMYLE: lick-mill, hapax. the only female mouse mentioned in the poem is given an appropriately gendered name: the mill in homer is worked by women (e.g. vii.104, xx.106), and is evidently frequented by mouse ladies as well:- PTERNOTROCTES: ham-nibble, hapax. psicharpax's pride in his ancestry is demonstrated by the way he, like glaucus, mentions more than just the previous generation. like the references to the weasel at 9 and 128, king pternotroctes contributes to an impression of the mice as a tribe with their own epic history:-